

BEGC-114 Postcolonial Literatures

Programme: BAEGH/2025-2026

Course Code: BEGC-114

(For July 2025 and January 2026 Sessions)

- Can be read as Model answers for understanding.
-

Answer all questions.

All questions carry equal marks.

(20 x 5 = 100)

1. Critically analyse Maami's role in Adjoa's life. How does her relationship with Nana affect the mother-daughter dynamics in the text?

The short story *The Girl Who Can* by Ama Ata Aidoo presents a household of three women: the grandmother Nana, the mother Maami, and the seven-year-old child Adjoa. The story is narrated through the eyes of Adjoa who observes the daily conversations, silences, and conflicts within this female household. The narrative deals with cultural expectations, reproductive roles, and the power of female solidarity. Within this framework, Maami plays a central but quiet role. Her silences, her small resistances, and her relationship with Nana directly affect how Adjoa grows and understands herself.

The story begins with Adjoa telling us that she was born in Hasodzi, “a very big village in the Central Region of our country, Ghana.” This childlike way of storytelling highlights how the entire story is filtered through the simple but sharp eyes of a child. The key conflict revolves around Adjoa's thin legs. Nana insists that the legs are “too thin and too long” and will not be strong enough for childbearing. Adjoa is confused because she can walk long distances and run very fast. Maami is caught in the middle, often silenced by her own mother but still trying to defend her daughter.

The role of Maami in Adjoa's life is shaped by her position between Nana's authority and Adjoa's innocence. Maami represents both weakness and courage. She is weak because she cannot openly oppose Nana, but she is courageous because she quietly takes steps to secure a better future for her daughter.

The first important aspect of Maami's role is her silence. Aidoo presents Maami as a woman who is constantly blamed for her choices. Nana scolds her for marrying a man who turned out to be irresponsible and absent. Adjoa hears Nana's voice again and again saying, "A man like that!" which reduces Maami's marriage to a mistake and her motherhood to a failure. Nana also blames her for giving birth to a girl with thin legs, as if Adjoa's body is entirely Maami's fault.

The silences of Maami are painful for Adjoa. The child narrator tells us that whenever Nana speaks harshly, Maami often becomes quiet, with "defeated tones and long looks." Adjoa cannot understand the full depth of her mother's sorrow, but she senses it. The silences reveal Maami's position as a marginalized woman within her own home. Although it is an all-female household, the hierarchy is clear: Nana dominates, Maami is suppressed, and Adjoa is observed and judged.

This silence also reflects the broader cultural context. In many matrilineal Ghanaian families, women carry both authority and responsibility. Yet even within this system, women like Maami are judged for circumstances beyond their control. Her silence shows how tradition often denies women the right to defend themselves.

Although Maami is silent most of the time, she is not entirely powerless. Her strength appears in small but significant acts. The most important act of resistance is her decision to send Adjoa to school. Nana thinks education is useless for a girl and believes a woman's purpose is to marry and bear children. However, Maami insists on education. She knows the "life of ignorance and darkness" she has suffered as an unlettered woman and does not want her daughter to experience the same.

This decision to educate Adjoa became the foundation of Adjoa's self-discovery. It is at school that Adjoa's talent for running is recognized. The same legs that Nana criticizes become the source of her victory and pride. When Adjoa wins the award for the best junior athlete, Nana changes her perception. She proudly carries the trophy on her back "like they do with the babies, and other precious things." This turning point is possible only because Maami had insisted on education.

Therefore, Maami's resistance is not through loud arguments but through practical action. She cannot silence her mother's taunts, but she ensures that her daughter will not remain trapped in the same cycle.

The relationship between Nana and Maami deeply shapes the mother-daughter dynamics in the text. Nana is presented as a strong, traditional matriarch. She believes in strict discipline, cultural customs, and the importance of reproduction. She tells Adjoa to keep quiet or to repeat statements for her amusement, and she constantly criticizes her legs. In contrast, Maami is caught between respecting her mother and protecting her child.

This power imbalance means that Maami rarely asserts herself openly. She becomes the “silent bridge” between tradition and change. Her silence is partly fear, partly habit, and partly cultural respect for her mother’s authority. But her relationship with Nana also teaches Adjoa about contradictions within family love. Adjoa loves both her grandmother and mother, but she sees them constantly disagreeing. She calls them her “two favourite people” yet feels confused at their quarrels.

Thus, Nana’s dominance forces Maami into silence, and Maami’s silence forces Adjoa to question things on her own. The grandmother’s harshness, the mother’s quiet endurance, and the child’s innocent observation create the layered dynamics of the household.

Despite her silence, Maami plays a crucial role in Adjoa’s self-discovery. She is the one who believes in her daughter’s education. She never discourages Adjoa or calls her legs useless. Unlike Nana, she does not silence her daughter’s voice. Instead, she allows Adjoa to speak, ask questions, and wonder. Even if she cannot always answer, her presence gives Adjoa emotional support.

When Adjoa finally wins the races, Maami feels absolved of guilt. She is no longer the failed mother who gave birth to a useless girl. She is proud but overwhelmed into silence once again. This silence is not defeat this time but relief and joy. The story closes with Adjoa feeling confused but happy that the adults around her have finally changed their view.

In this way, Maami’s role is subtle but powerful. She represents a generation of women who may not have had the strength to fight loudly but who enabled the next generation to rise higher.

The silence of Maami carries symbolic meaning. It shows how women have often been pushed to the margins within their own homes. It also highlights how change sometimes begins not through dramatic rebellion but through quiet persistence. Her relationship with Nana is not just personal but also cultural, it reflects the conflict between tradition and modernity in postcolonial Ghana.

Through Maami, Aidoo also critiques the unfair burden placed on women. A man who abandons his wife is simply “a man like that.” but the woman is held responsible forever. Maami’s silence is both a symbol of suffering and a quiet form of resistance.

The role of Maami in Adjoa’s life is that of a silent sufferer and a quiet resister. Her relationship with Nana shapes the entire household dynamic. Nana represents tradition, authority, and criticism, while Maami represents silence, endurance, and subtle courage. Adjoa grows up between these two forces, learning to question, to run, and to discover her own agency.

The story shows that Maami may not have had a loud voice, but her decisions, especially sending Adjoa to school, changed the direction of her daughter’s life. Her silence mirrors the oppression

of women in society, but her quiet actions open the door for Adjoa's empowerment. The conflict between Nana and Maami therefore creates the conditions for Adjoa's growth. By the end, when Nana proudly carries the trophy and Maami feels absolved, the family finds a new balance.

Ama Ata Aidoo thus uses Maami's role to show how women's silences, struggles, and subtle acts of resistance shape the lives of future generations.

2. *July's People* is an anti-Apartheid dystopian text. Discuss.

The novel *July's People* (1981) by Nadine Gordimer is a strong anti-apartheid dystopian text. The story imagines the fall of apartheid before it actually happened in South Africa. It presents a fictional civil war that forces the white middle-class Smales family to leave their privileged city life in Johannesburg and take refuge in the village of their long-time black servant, July. The text combines political vision with personal struggles and shows the collapse of old systems of power.

The dystopian element comes from Gordimer's portrayal of a society in chaos, where familiar roles are reversed, and nothing is secure. The anti-apartheid message is clear, as the narrative questions the false stability of white power and exposes the inequalities of the system. Through shifts in dependence, tensions in relationships, and the uncertainty of the future, the novel explores the breakdown of apartheid and the painful birth of something new.

The beginning of the novel immediately shows this reversal of roles. July, who was once the servant of the Smales family, now becomes their saviour. He provides them with shelter and food, while they depend on his knowledge of rural life. Gordimer writes that July "still performs his role of servant, that day for them as his kind has always done for their kind". This sentence highlights the irony. The Smaleses expect July to act in the same old way, but the reality has changed. The civil war has destroyed the city, and in the village July is no longer a servant but a man with his own authority. The clash between the known and the unknown creates unease and signals a dystopian atmosphere.

The setting reinforces the idea of displacement and loss. The Smales family moves into a mud hut with no doors, insects everywhere, and limited resources. Gordimer describes: "The knock on the door, no door, an aperture in thick mud walls, and the sack that hung over it looped back for air... No knock; but July, their servant, their host, bringing two pink glass cups of tea". The image of a door replaced by a sack is symbolic. It shows the destruction of middle-class comforts and the dismantling of polite rituals. For the Smales, the past world of secure houses and orderly manners is gone, replaced by a rough life in survival mode.

The dystopian mood also appears in the way the Smales family loses material privileges. Their children sleep on seats taken out of the truck instead of proper beds. Their car, the “bakkie,” becomes both a lifeline and a symbol of their fragile hold on security. When Bamford hides the vehicle on July’s advice, the irony of their dependence becomes clear. They are no longer masters giving orders; they are fugitives who must listen to July in order to survive. The inversion of roles points to the collapse of apartheid hierarchy.

The anti-apartheid theme is also visible in the doubts expressed by July’s family. His wife Martha and his mother cannot believe that whites have lost their power. July’s mother says with disbelief: “White people. They are very powerful, my son. They are very clever. You will never come to the end of the things they can do”. This reveals how deeply apartheid ideology had shaped the minds of black South Africans, making them believe that whites could never be defeated. Gordimer shows that even after the system falls, its psychological scars remain.

The Smaleses themselves show the failure of white liberalism. Maureen and Bamford had always thought of themselves as progressive and sympathetic towards black people. But in the village, their so-called liberal values break down. Maureen realises that her past experiences cannot prepare her for the present. She reflects: “No fiction could compete with what she was finding she did not know, could not have imagined or discovered through imagination”. Literature, comfort, and city liberalism are useless when faced with the harsh reality of survival.

The novel also reveals how apartheid shaped personal relationships through power and dependence. July reminds Maureen that for fifteen years he worked for her and was trusted with house keys. When she doubts his use of the bakkie, he angrily asks, “You not going pay me, this month?”. This question cuts through her illusions of friendship and mutual respect. Their relationship was always based on economics and necessity. For July, service was never about loyalty to the Smales family but about providing for his own family. The anti-apartheid message here is strong: the system was never about equality or genuine respect, but about exploitation.

The dystopian quality grows as mistrust increases. Maureen begins to fear July, not for physical harm but because of his new authority. Gordimer describes her realisation that her special treatment of July in the past may now become his humiliation. The world has turned upside down, and roles are no longer fixed. This instability is the heart of dystopia.

The chief of the village also shows the confusion of the transitional period. When the Smaleses are taken to him, he refuses to believe that the white government is collapsing. He insists that the government will give him guns to fight against black rebels: “They give us guns, we going kill those people when they come with their guns”. His words reveal the fragmentation among black leaders and the lingering fear of change. Instead of unity, there is division and dependence on

white authority. The dystopian element here is the uncertainty of the revolution itself. The old order is gone, but the new one is not yet secure.

The novel also criticises the false comforts of the past. Maureen remembers her childhood days when Lydia, a black servant, carried her school case. At the time she never questioned it, but later she saw the photograph in a book and realised the injustice. This memory shows how apartheid shaped daily life in invisible but powerful ways. Gordimer uses such recollections to highlight how the system was built into the smallest details of existence.

The narrative style itself adds to the dystopian tone. Gordimer writes in a fragmented, unsettling way that forces readers to feel disoriented. The lack of clear facts and the frequent shifts in time make the story feel uncertain. This mirrors the confusion of the characters, who cannot predict the future. Zoë Wicomb explains this as part of the “Gramscian interregnum,” a time of crisis when the old system is dying but the new one has not yet been born. The novel captures this painful in-between space.

The ending of the novel is famously open. Maureen runs towards a helicopter, leaving behind her family. It is not clear whether she seeks rescue, death, or escape. The uncertainty reflects the uncertainty of South Africa’s future in 1981. The dystopia is not complete destruction but an unresolved transition.

In conclusion, *July’s People* is both anti-apartheid and dystopian. The novel attacks the injustices of apartheid by showing the false security of white power, the exploitation behind servant-master relationships, and the psychological scars on both blacks and whites. At the same time, it presents a dystopian vision of a collapsing world, where nothing is certain, and survival depends on new, uncomfortable relationships. The novel remains a classic example of how literature can imagine political change and reveal the hidden truths of a society built on inequality.

3. What is the significance of the title of the story “The Green Leaves”?

The title of Grace Ogot’s short story *The Green Leaves* holds deep symbolic, cultural, and thematic significance. The story itself is about the Luo community in Kenya, their customs, their beliefs, their struggles with colonial laws, and most importantly, about how greed leads to personal destruction. The green leaves, which are usually associated with life, freshness, and renewal, in this story become connected with death, tragedy, and betrayal. The irony of the title reveals how something natural and positive can turn into a symbol of loss, suspicion, and moral failure.

The story begins with a scene of commotion when Nyagar, one of the main characters, hears the sounds of cattle thieves being pursued. The thieves are caught and beaten, and one of them appears to be killed. As part of their custom, the villagers cover the body of the thief with green leaves. This act of covering the body gives the title its first meaning. The leaves are not just vegetation here; they are a marker of death and concealment. Grace Ogot writes, “They tore green leaves from nearby trees and covered the victim completely with them.” What seems to be an ordinary ritual of the community later becomes the turning point of the whole story. The heap of green leaves becomes a hiding place not of a dead thief, but of Nyagar himself, the villager who is destroyed by his own greed.

The green leaves symbolize concealment and mystery. When Nyagar goes secretly in the night to search for the body of the so-called thief, he uncovers the leaves, believing that he will find money. He bends over the body and is struck fatally. The leaves, which once covered the thief, now cover Nyagar’s body. This shift of the leaves from the thief to Nyagar gives the title its shocking and ironic significance. The villagers, who believe that they had killed a thief, wake up to the shocking discovery that it is Nyagar’s body that lies beneath the heap. Grace Ogot describes the moment of disbelief: “Olielo looked at the body before them unbelievably. Then he looked at his people, and at the police. Was he normal? Where was the thief? ... It was the body of Nyagar, his cousin, who lay dead.” The green leaves therefore become a symbol of fate, of how greed transforms life into death, and of how uncertainty shakes the foundation of community trust.

The leaves also symbolize the irony of life and death. In many cultures, green leaves stand for hope, new beginnings, and growth. In the Luo community as well, leaves are connected with rituals of protection and burial. Yet in this story, the leaves are associated with decay and tragedy. The title is ironic because what should symbolize life instead becomes a cover for death. Instead of giving peace, the leaves bring confusion and suspicion. The narrator even highlights that the leaves, which usually suggest optimism, here become a sign of “death, disintegration, discord and distrust among the people of the tribe.” This change of meaning shows how human actions, particularly greed, can corrupt even the pure symbols of nature.

The green leaves further represent the clash of ideologies. For the Luo people, covering a thief with leaves is part of their custom and belief system. They do not see it as murder, but as justice. The clan elder Olielo even explains, “Although our laws prohibit any wanton killing, thieves and adulterers we regard as animals. If anyone kills one of them he is not guilty of murder. He is looked upon as a person who has rid society of an evil spirit.” In their cultural practice, the green leaves are part of restoring order. However, the colonial officer sees things differently. For him, no person is guilty until proven so in a court of law. The green leaves, in this sense, become a symbol of the conflict between native laws and colonial laws. What is seen by the Luo as a ritual

of justice appears to the white officer as a sign of barbarity. The title thus carries within it the tension of postcolonial life where traditions clash with imposed systems.

The green leaves also symbolize human greed. Nyagar himself is a wealthy man. He has three wives, twelve children, cattle, and enough food. He does not need more wealth. Yet he is tempted by the thought that the thief might be carrying money. His inner voice warns him: “What do you want to do with money? You have three wives and twelve children. You have many cattle and enough food. What more do you want?” But his greed pushes him forward, and he dies because of it. The green leaves that cover him in the end become a symbol of how human desires, when uncontrolled, can destroy even the strongest man. Instead of being remembered as a good father and husband, Nyagar becomes the example of greed’s fatal power.

The title also reflects family and social breakdown. After Nyagar’s death, his wife Nyamundhe is left broken and suspicious. She cries over her husband’s body and questions the men who claimed to have killed a thief. She says bitterly, “Where is the thief you killed? Where is he?” The green leaves that cover her husband’s body sow suspicion in her heart. She does not believe the other men, and her trust in society is shattered. The leaves therefore symbolize how one act of greed can destroy family harmony and create divisions in the community.

The title further reflects the theme of superstition. In the story, when Nyagar feels the dead thief’s hand still warm, he dismisses it as a supernatural sign instead of using his common sense. He convinces himself that the man is dead. The belief in signs, omens, and superstitions runs throughout the story, as even Nyamundhe mentions the bad omen of a black cat crossing their path. The green leaves, as an object of ritual, are part of this world of belief. But at the same time, the story shows how blind faith in such customs can lead to destruction.

The story also presents the green leaves as a metaphor for society’s fragile unity. In the beginning, the villagers act together. They chase the thieves as one body, and they perform rituals together. But after the green leaves reveal Nyagar’s body, unity breaks apart. Suspicion, disbelief, and grief spread among them. The leaves, instead of uniting them, divide them. The title therefore reflects the collapse of trust within a close-knit community.

The green leaves also highlight the theme of irony in human life. Nyagar joins the group to fight thieves and protect society. He appears to be a responsible man. Yet the same night, because of greed, he becomes the victim. The leaves that were supposed to cover the thief cover him instead. This cruel twist of fate shows the irony of life and death. The title captures this irony perfectly.

The green leaves in the story finally symbolize how personal flaws can affect the entire community. Nyagar’s greed not only destroys him but also shakes the confidence of his wife, his

relatives, and his people. His death becomes a communal tragedy. The green leaves therefore stand not just for one man's downfall but for the danger that selfish desires pose to social order.

The title *The Green Leaves* is therefore full of meaning. It symbolizes concealment, irony, superstition, cultural conflict, greed, family tragedy, and social breakdown. Grace Ogot uses the image of leaves, something natural and common, to carry layers of meaning about human life. The story shows that life and death, tradition and modernity, unity and division, all can be hidden under something as simple as a heap of green leaves. The title is significant because it forces the reader to reflect on how symbols of life can become symbols of death, how greed can destroy even the wealthy, and how cultural practices can both unite and divide a community.

Thus the green leaves remind us that in human life, what looks simple may conceal deep truths. The title becomes not only a literal reference to the leaves used in the burial ritual but also a metaphor for the hidden forces of greed, irony, and fate that shape human existence.

4. The title of the poem “A Far Cry from Africa” is ambiguous and ironic. Comment.

The title of **Derek Walcott's** poem *A Far Cry from Africa* carries deep meaning, and its ambiguity and irony. The words of the title suggest more than one meaning, and this double or multiple meaning creates a powerful background for the poet's theme of conflict, identity, and alienation.

The poem itself was written in **1962** and refers to the **Mau Mau** uprising in Kenya against British colonial rule. The uprising was marked by great violence from both sides. Walcott, who was of mixed African and European heritage, found himself caught in between. He loved the English language and culture, yet he also felt the pull of his African ancestry. The title of the poem already reflects this inner conflict.

The phrase “*A Far Cry*” has at least two possible meanings. On one level, it means a loud cry that comes from a long distance, something that can be heard faintly from far away. On another level, it means something very different or opposite from what is expected. The addition of “*from Africa*” in the title creates both distance and connection. The cry is far away, yet it is linked to Africa. The title therefore is ambiguous because it is not clear whether the cry comes from Africa, or whether the speaker is far removed from Africa, or whether Africa itself is “a far cry” from the poet's own life and position.

The irony in the title comes from the fact that Walcott is of African descent, yet he feels distanced from Africa. He belongs to Africa by blood, but he does not belong fully to its land or

its struggles. He is both an insider and an outsider. His own words in the poem highlight this painful division:

*"I who am poisoned with the blood of both,
Where shall I turn, divided to the vein?"*

This confession shows that although Africa is part of his identity, it is also far from him, almost unreachable. Therefore, the cry from Africa is both his own cry and not his own at the same time. That is why the title is ironic.

The ambiguity can be explained further with examples from the poem. The poet begins by describing the African landscape:

"A wind is ruffling the tawny pelt of Africa."

Here Africa is compared to an animal skin, beautiful yet disturbed by violence. The Kikuyu tribe, who led the rebellion, are described as "quick as flies" feeding upon the land. The corpses of the dead are scattered across a land that should have been paradise. This vision of Africa is both full of life and full of death. The irony is that Africa is a place of natural beauty, yet it becomes the site of brutal conflict.

The ambiguity of the title reflects this contradiction. The cry from Africa is a cry of pain, but it is also a cry of strength. It is a call for freedom, but it is also a reminder of destruction. The poet's inability to fully embrace either side makes the cry "far" from him.

The irony also lies in Walcott's relationship with the English language. The poet admits his love for the English tongue even as he condemns British colonialism. He says:

*"I who have cursed
The drunken officer of British rule, how choose
Between this Africa and the English tongue I love?"*

This is ironic because the very language he uses to condemn colonialism is the gift of colonialism itself. He cannot separate himself from the colonizer's culture. The cry from Africa should naturally be his own, yet because of his divided inheritance, it becomes "a far cry."

The title also becomes ironic when we think about the word "cry." A cry usually suggests unity, emotion, or a call that is recognized by others. But Walcott's cry is one of division. He cannot decide whether to stand with Africa or with Europe. He asks:

*"How can I face such slaughter and be cool?
How can I turn from Africa and live?"*

These rhetorical questions show that his cry is not a simple one of anger or grief. It is a cry of confusion. Therefore, the cry is “far” even from himself.

The ambiguity deepens when we remember that Walcott was Caribbean, not African. The Caribbean identity is itself hybrid, born of African, European, and indigenous influences. The history of slavery, colonization, and cultural mixing created a sense of rootlessness. The poet looks at Africa as a place of origin, but it is also a place he has never truly known. Thus, the cry from Africa is distant in space and time. It is his ancestral past, but not his present life. This makes the title doubly ambiguous.

The irony is sharper because the Mau Mau uprising in Kenya was a fight against colonialism, and Walcott too was shaped by colonial rule. Yet his response is not straightforward support for the Africans. He is horrified by the violence of the rebels as well as by the cruelty of the colonizers. He calls it a fight where “*the gorilla wrestles with the superman*.” The metaphor shows Africans being compared to gorillas by the colonial mindset, while Europeans see themselves as supermen. Walcott rejects both images, yet he is forced to see the violence from both sides. His position makes him unable to fully join the cry of Africa, and so again it becomes “a far cry.”

The title also has irony when seen in terms of geography. Walcott writes from the Caribbean, thousands of miles away from Africa. He is physically distant. Yet the violence in Kenya touches him deeply because it is also the story of his own people’s history. This mixture of closeness and distance is exactly what the title suggests.

The ambiguity also lies in the way the cry is received. For the Africans, it is a cry of pain and resistance. For the colonizers, it may be a cry of savagery. For the poet, it is a cry that pulls him in two directions. The title does not explain whose cry it is, or how it should be understood. That lack of clarity is intentional and reflects the poet’s own divided state of mind.

The irony of the title also lies in the fact that poetry itself becomes the cry. Walcott transforms his dilemma into art. The far cry from Africa is not only the sound of violence but also the sound of his poem. What should have been a simple act of taking sides becomes instead a complex act of creation. The poem itself is an example of how art can rise out of confusion and conflict.

The ambiguity of the title is also linked to language. Critics like Carolyn Cooper have pointed out that Walcott’s struggle with English and Creole represents a deeper cultural conflict. English is the colonizer’s language, yet it is the tool through which Walcott expresses his identity. Africa is symbolized by Creole and folk culture, but he cannot give up English. Thus, his cry for identity is distant, mixed, and full of irony.

The final effect of the title is to leave the reader unsettled. The cry from Africa cannot be easily answered. It remains far, divided, and unresolved. This matches the poem’s ending, where

Walcott leaves his questions unanswered. The ambiguity of the title mirrors the ambiguity of his identity. The irony of the title mirrors the irony of his existence as a Caribbean poet with African and European blood.

Therefore, the title *A Far Cry from Africa* is both ambiguous and ironic. It suggests distance and closeness, similarity and difference, belonging and alienation. It reflects the poet's divided heritage and his inability to choose between Africa and Europe. It captures the violence of history and the complexity of identity. It shows how a simple phrase can carry multiple layers of meaning.

5. Critically examine the role of the human wall in the play “Ghashiram Kotwal”.

The human wall in **Vijay Tendulkar's** play *Ghashiram Kotwal* is not just a group of silent figures standing on stage. It is a living, breathing presence that gives the play its rhythm, its commentary, and its theatrical power. The wall of men represents both the society of Pune and the audience of the play. It connects the events of the story to the larger world outside the stage. Through song, dance, music, and dialogue, the wall comments on power, morality, corruption, and cruelty.

The human wall first functions as a chorus. In traditional Sanskrit and folk theatre, the chorus or the *sutradhar* guides the audience. Tendulkar uses the wall in a similar way but also reshapes it for modern theatre. The wall introduces the setting of Pune and sings about the political environment under the Peshwas. For example, the wall sings in praise of Nana Phadnavis, “Nana is wise, Nana is great.” This praise is not innocent. It is exaggerated and ironic. It makes the audience see how the people were taught to admire authority blindly, even when that authority was corrupt.

The wall also acts as public opinion. Whenever Ghashiram rises in power or punishes the people, the wall reflects the mood of the citizens. The wall sings about Ghashiram's cruelty: “Now in Pune there is only fear, fear in every house.” This role is important because it shows how ordinary people suffer when leaders misuse power. The wall is not a single individual but a collective voice. It gives shape to the silent majority of society.

The wall further functions as a moral commentator. Instead of giving a direct lecture, Tendulkar allows the wall to judge the events in symbolic ways. When Ghashiram begins to arrest innocent people, the wall mocks the excess: “No man can walk free, no woman can breathe free, the city has become a prison.” By repeating such lines, the wall becomes the conscience of the play. It shows what happens when justice is replaced by fear.

The wall is also important for the musical structure of the play. *Ghashiram Kotwal* is written in the style of *tamasha*, a Marathi folk form filled with music, dance, and satire. The wall sings *lavani* songs, claps, and stamps feet. This keeps the energy of the play alive and makes the scenes flow smoothly. When Nana flirts with women, the wall sings teasing lines that expose his hypocrisy. When Ghashiram gains power, the wall beats drums and chants like a crowd in a marketplace. These devices help the audience to feel that the events are both entertainment and political critique.

The wall also serves as a bridge between history and theatre. The play is set in the eighteenth century, but Tendulkar wants to show that the same issues of corruption and misuse of power exist in modern India. The human wall reminds the audience that what they see on stage is not only about Ghashiram and Nana. It is also about every system where rulers use ordinary people for their selfish gains.

The wall also creates distance and irony, similar to the style of Bertolt Brecht. Instead of making the audience identify with a single hero, Tendulkar makes the wall comment from outside the action. This stops the audience from feeling pity for Ghashiram alone. Instead, it makes them think about the social system that created both Ghashiram and his fall. For example, when Ghashiram is finally punished and dragged away, the wall does not weep for him. It sings coldly: "*Ghashiram is dead, long live another Ghashiram.*" This shows that the cycle of power and cruelty will continue, and individuals are only instruments in a larger corrupt structure.

The wall also plays the role of storyteller. Instead of using elaborate sets, Tendulkar allows the wall to set the scene. The men move, sing, and form shapes that suggest prison walls, city gates, or court crowds. This makes the stage simple but powerful. For example, when Ghashiram orders the arrest of citizens, the human wall closes in tightly, turning into a prison before the audience's eyes. This symbolic use of bodies replaces physical scenery and shows how the theatre itself can become alive.

The wall also highlights the theme of dehumanisation. By forming a wall, the men lose their individual identity. They become a faceless crowd, just like the common people under oppressive rule. They sing together, clap together, and move together. This loss of individuality reflects how political power reduces citizens to mere numbers. When the wall chants about Ghashiram's cruelty, it is both a protest and a reminder that the people themselves are trapped in the same structure.

The wall is also a mirror for the audience. When the wall laughs at Nana's immoral behaviour, the audience is forced to laugh too, but then feel uneasy. When the wall shouts about injustice, the audience is reminded of their own silence in front of authority. In this way, the wall breaks

the distance between the stage and the spectators. It makes the audience realise that they too are part of the same society that produces figures like Nana and Ghashiram.

The wall also acts as a ritual element. In classical Indian drama, the *sutradhar* begins the play with invocations. Tendulkar transforms this by making the wall both religious and ironic. At times, the wall sings devotional songs, but these are placed next to scenes of corruption and lust. This clash shows how religion and morality are often used as covers for selfish desires.

The wall finally brings out the tragic irony of Ghashiram's life. Ghashiram rises to power by serving Nana and suppressing the people. The wall first mocks him as an outsider, then fears him as a tyrant, and finally watches his fall. But instead of sympathy, the wall offers a lesson: rulers come and go, but exploitation remains. By chanting lines like "One Ghashiram goes, another will come," the wall makes the play not only about one man but about the endless cycle of power in society.

In conclusion, the human wall in *Ghashiram Kotwal* is central to the structure and meaning of the play. It acts as chorus, commentator, storyteller, crowd, conscience, and mirror. It forces the audience to see the deeper themes of corruption, power, and oppression. By combining traditional folk theatre with modern political critique, Tendulkar makes the human wall both a dramatic device and a moral voice. The wall reminds us that tyranny does not survive without silent acceptance from society.
